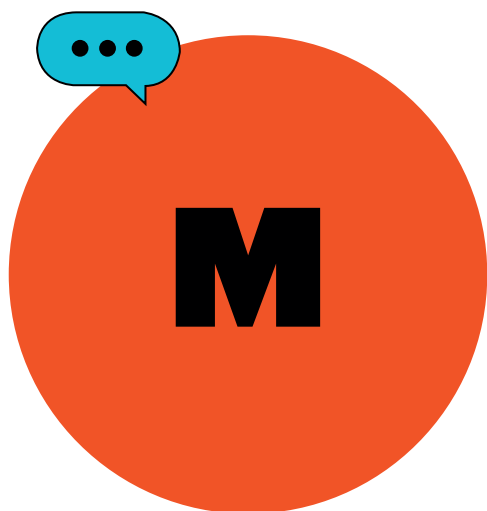




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MANOJ RAGHAVAN recalls at least two occasions when he had to take the wheel after a long overseas flight into Bengaluru. Before you start to wonder why he would do that in the early hours after an arduous travel schedule, it was simply because the driver was dangerously close to nodding off to sleep.

There is possibly nothing remarkably unusual about this except that our conversation with Raghavan is on driverless cars. And as CEO & Managing Director of Tata Elxsi, a name in global design and technology services, he is completely involved in what could be a defining moment in the automobile industry. “Imagine you are sitting in a vehicle that is zipping away at 100 km an hour without a driver. It is only natural for your heart to be pounding,” he says with a laugh. The inevitable question that will cross your mind would be if your car is awake. “And if you are dealing with tough weather conditions like rain, what assurance can a passenger have sitting alone in the car?”

As you sit back to paint the world a decade or two from now, where technology will dictate almost everything we do, the possibilities are endless. Autonomous driving, entertainment, healthcare, using the mobile phone or just any of the mundane activities we are involved in are just a few things that come to mind. Tata Elxsi already has a play in most of these areas and looks well-positioned to be in a lot more. “There is some very interesting stuff that we are working on,” says Raghavan, without giving away much. This is a business where customer confidentiality is para-

mount and one has to pick those little nuggets to understand the potential of the company’s business. For Tata Elxsi, it is a classic confluence between design, technology and delivery, and in a world as unpredictable as ours, that is quite fascinating.

DIAL D FOR DISRUPTION

While these are exciting times for Tata Elxsi—that provides design and technology services to businesses across industries—it is also critical to have a strategy that helps the company to pull out quickly if the need be. As Nitin Pai, Tata Elxsi’s CMO and Chief Strategy Officer says, “As a company, we have to be prepared for disruption and should also be able to disrupt.”

Take the case of OTT (over-the-top or providing content over the internet at the viewer’s convenience), with the company getting started on this as far back as 2013. The trend the company saw was interesting in more ways than one. Initially, it worked with set-top box (STB) manufacturers in their embedded hardware. It helped viewers save shows that they missed, with the idea of watching them later—think of STBs that allowed you to record a show or series. “It was still cumbersome. Around that time, IPTV (internet protocol television or the delivery of video content over the internet) started coming in,” says Raghavan. As it turned out, this was the most interesting period for IPTV, with a plethora of smartphones and tablets being launched around that time. “It was right for disruption with many things coming together,” he adds. To that extent, OTT taking off was hardly a surprise to Tata Elxsi. The inefficiency in recording a programme to watch it later was not feasible. “Now, content is delivered from the cloud and you can watch it anytime,” says Pai, adding that the company was ready for this transformation—it was already working with names such as Airtel and ZEE5 then.

“We are not a typical IT company. We are a focussed player in the ER&D (engineering, research and development) space with the good part being that we don’t try to hit every nail with a hammer,” says Raghavan. The tack is to instead focus on a few verticals—transport, media and communications, healthcare and medical devices—and attain expertise in each. “The first 10 minutes of a conversation with a customer is enough for him to be convinced about our depth or